

PC Trap-Pattern Pack

Pick the right answer fast. Kill the trap choices first. Cite the line every time.

THE 60-SECOND TRIAGE CARD

1. **Read the question first** so you know what to hunt for.
2. **Mark key words** in the stem: NOT, EXCEPT, BEST, MAIN.
3. **Skim the passage** for the proof sentence, not for plot.
4. **Predict the answer** in your own words before reading choices.
5. **Eliminate trap choices** using the 5 patterns on page 2.
6. **Verify with a line.** If you cannot point at it, it is not the answer.

- 02 The 5 trap patterns, weaponized
- 03 Three worked passages with every wrong choice labeled
- 04 Four-passage drill set (you solve)
- 05 Answer key + test-day cue card

The 5 wrong-answer traps

Every wrong choice on PC fits one of these patterns. Spot the pattern, kill the choice, save the time.

1. True-but-not-asked

Real fact from the passage, but does not answer this question.

Fact: The museum opens at 9 a.m. and offers free tours.

Q: Why do visitors line up early?

Trap: It opens at 9 a.m.

Right: They want seats for the first tour.

2. Plausible synonym swap

Near-match word, but the meaning shifted just enough to be wrong.

Fact: The road was narrow, so trucks moved slowly.

Q: What does "narrow" mean here?

Trap: empty

Right: not wide

3. Overclaim

Turns a limited fact into a sweeping rule using always, never, all, none.

Fact: Some seedlings grew faster in shade.

Q: What does the sentence suggest?

Trap: Shade is always best for every plant.

Right: Shade helped some seedlings grow faster.

4. Detail outside passage

Adds information the passage never provides, even if it sounds reasonable.

Fact: The chef chilled the dough before baking.

Q: Why was the dough chilled?

Trap: Because butter melts at a specific temperature.

Right: The passage does not say.

5. Half right

One piece is true, the other piece is wrong. Looks correct on a quick skim.

Fact: The bus was late because traffic blocked the main street.

Q: Why was the bus late?

Trap: Traffic blocked the street after the driver took a shortcut.

Right: Traffic blocked the main street.

QUESTION TYPE TO MOST LIKELY TRAP

QUESTION TYPE	TRAP TO EXPECT	KILL MOVE
Detail	True-but-not-asked, Half right	Match the question stem word-for-word.
Main idea	Overclaim, Half right	Cross out absolutes. Pick the choice that fits the whole passage.
Vocab-in-context	Plausible synonym swap	Re-read the sentence with the choice plugged in.
Inference	Detail outside passage, Overclaim	Demand passage support, not common-sense support.
EXCEPT / NOT	True-but-not-asked	Three choices match the passage. Pick the one that does not.

Worked passages: see the elimination on paper

Three passages, every wrong choice labeled with its trap pattern. Read like an answer key, not an article.

Passage 1: Public Libraries and Local Support **DETAIL**

In the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, many towns began opening public libraries. Before that shift, books were often expensive and hard for ordinary workers to borrow. Reformers argued that free access to reading could help people strengthen job skills, learn about government, and enjoy literature at home. Some wealthy donors paid for library buildings, but local communities still had to hire staff, buy books, and maintain the property. Because of that shared investment, libraries became more than quiet storage rooms. They developed into civic spaces where children studied after school, adults read newspapers, and neighbors gathered for lectures or reading groups.

According to the passage, what did local communities still need to do after a donor paid for a library building?

A. Host lectures and reading groups for neighbors **TRUE-BUT-NOT-ASKED**

Lectures are mentioned, but the question asks what communities had to do, not what happened inside.

B. Hire staff, buy books, and maintain the property ✓

C. Follow a national rule that forced every town to open one **OVERCLAIM**

No national rule is mentioned. The choice invents a sweeping requirement.

D. Construct the building with donated labor **HALF RIGHT**

Buildings are discussed, but the passage says donors paid for them, not that labor was donated.

Passage 2: What Public Hearings Do **MAIN IDEA**

Before a city council approves a major zoning change or a new public project, it often holds a public hearing. At the hearing, residents can ask questions, express concerns, or support the proposal in a formal setting. Officials may also hear practical information that does not appear in written reports, such as traffic patterns near a school or noise near a neighborhood park. A hearing does not mean every speaker gets the preferred outcome, and it does not replace the final vote by elected leaders. Instead, it gives decision makers a clearer view of how a plan may affect daily life in the community.

What is the main idea of the passage?

A. Public hearings guarantee that residents control the final vote. **OVERCLAIM**

The passage says residents may speak, not that they control the vote.

B. Public hearings are mostly formal ceremonies held after projects are approved. **HALF RIGHT**

Hearings are formal, but the passage says they happen before approval, not after.

C. Public hearings give officials local input before final decisions are made. ✓

D. Public hearings exist mainly to train residents for elected office. **DETAIL OUTSIDE PASSAGE**

Training residents for office is never mentioned in the passage.

Passage 3: Why Deserts Cool Quickly **VOCABULARY-IN-CONTEXT**

Deserts are known for intense daytime heat, but many deserts become surprisingly cool after sunset. One reason is that dry air holds less water vapor than humid air. Water vapor can help trap heat near the ground, so when little of it is present, warmth escapes more easily into the atmosphere at night. In addition, deserts often have few clouds, which means less insulation overhead after the sun goes down. Sand and rock may heat quickly during the day, yet they do not retain that warmth for long once the source of heat is gone. As a result, daily temperature changes in deserts can be dramatic.

In the passage, the word “retain” most nearly means

A. hide **DETAIL OUTSIDE PASSAGE**

The passage explains heat storage, not concealment.

B. measure **PLAUSIBLE SYNONYM SWAP**

“Measure” sounds scientific, but here the word means to hold onto something.

C. release **HALF RIGHT**

The passage does describe heat escaping later, but “retain” means the opposite of release.

D. keep ✓

Drill set: you solve, no answers on this page

Mark the trap label next to each wrong choice you eliminate. Underline the line that proves your pick. Answer key on page 5.

Passage 4: Organizing Shared Tools **INFERENCE**

At a neighborhood print shop, employees share paper cutters, rulers, and specialty hole punches throughout the day. For months, staff members set these tools down at whatever table was nearby when a rush order arrived. The habit seemed harmless, but it created delays when the next worker had to search several stations before finishing a job. The manager responded by labeling storage spots and adding a simple sign-out board for the most frequently borrowed tools. Within two weeks, fewer orders were late, and employees spent less time interrupting one another to ask where an item had gone. The new system did not add equipment, but it made the existing equipment easier to find.

Which of the following can reasonably be inferred about the shop before the new system was introduced?

- A. The shop needed to buy many more tools.
- B. Workers often lost time looking for shared tools.
- C. Every employee ignored written directions on purpose.
- D. The manager had recently reduced the number of orders.

Passage 5: Life on a River Delta **EXCEPT / NOT**

River deltas form where a river slows and drops much of the sand, silt, and clay it has carried downstream. Over time, these materials build low, flat land crossed by branching channels of water. Many deltas become valuable places for farming because the deposited soil is often fertile. They can also support fishing, transportation, and dense plant growth. At the same time, deltas are changeable landscapes. A channel may shift course, floodwater may spread widely, and coastlines may slowly move as sediment builds or washes away. People who live in deltas often benefit from abundant natural resources, but they also must adapt to a landscape that does not stay fixed.

According to the passage, river deltas often have all of the following EXCEPT

- A. fertile soil
- B. branching water channels
- C. tall cliffs of exposed rock
- D. convenient conditions for transport

Passage 6: How Skin Repairs a Cut **DETAIL**

When skin is cut, the body begins repairs almost immediately. First, blood vessels narrow for a short time, which helps reduce bleeding. Platelets then gather at the injury and form a clot, creating a temporary seal over the opening. As the clot dries, it becomes a scab that protects the area from dirt and germs. Beneath that cover, new skin cells multiply and move across the damaged surface. Small blood vessels also regrow, bringing oxygen and nutrients that support healing. Minor cuts usually mend on their own, although deeper wounds may require medical care because the body has more tissue to rebuild.

According to the passage, what forms first to create a temporary seal over a cut?

- A. A dry scab that appears before any clot
- B. A bandage-like layer of new skin cells
- C. A clot made by gathered platelets
- D. A new layer of muscle tissue

Passage 7: Sequence Words in Instructions **MAIN IDEA**

Clear instructions depend on more than correct facts. They also depend on order. Writers often use sequence words such as first, next, then, and finally to guide readers through a process one step at a time. These cues are especially useful when a task includes several actions that must occur in the proper order, such as assembling furniture or following a recipe. Without sequence words, even accurate directions can feel crowded or confusing because readers may not know which action belongs where. Strong instruction writing does not need fancy language. It needs structure that helps a reader move from one step to the next without guessing.

What is the main idea of the passage?

- A. Long instructions are always better than short ones.
- B. Sequence words are used only in school writing.
- C. Instruction writing succeeds mainly when it sounds formal.
- D. Good instructions rely on sequence words to make the order of steps clear.

Answer key with trap diagnosis

The trap pattern that caught you is your study plan. If the same trap repeats, drill that one until you spot it cold.

- 4 **B. Workers often lost time looking for shared tools.**
A. **Half right.** Tools were part of the problem, but the issue was organization, not a shortage.
C. **Overclaim.** The passage describes a messy habit, not deliberate refusal by every employee.
D. **Detail outside passage.** No reduction in orders is mentioned anywhere.
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- 5 **C. tall cliffs of exposed rock.**
A. **True-but-not-asked.** Fertile soil is in the passage, so it cannot be the EXCEPT answer.
B. **True-but-not-asked.** Branching channels are directly described in the passage.
D. **True-but-not-asked.** Transportation is listed as a benefit of deltas.
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- 6 **C. A clot made by gathered platelets.**
A. **Half right.** A scab does form, but only after the clot dries.
B. **Half right.** New skin cells appear later in healing, not as the first temporary seal.
D. **Detail outside passage.** Muscle tissue is not part of the process described.
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- 7 **D. Good instructions rely on sequence words to make the order of steps clear.**
A. **Overclaim.** The passage discusses clarity and order, not a rule that longer is always better.
B. **Detail outside passage.** The passage gives general uses for sequence words, not only school writing.
C. **Plausible synonym swap.** Formal language sounds organized, but the passage says structure, not formality, creates clarity.
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TEST-DAY CUE CARD

1. **Read the question first.**
2. **Mark key words** in the stem, especially NOT, EXCEPT, and BEST.
3. **Read the passage** for purpose, tone, and proof.
4. **Predict the answer** in your own words before checking the choices.
5. **Eliminate trap choices** that overclaim or go outside the passage.
6. **Verify with one line** from the passage before you submit.